does not acknowledge the superiority of even *brāhmaṇas* on the basis of their birth alone. The famous story of Satyakāma Jābāla in the *Chāndogya Upaniṣad* is refreshingly pertinent in this connection.[10] In the *Mahābhārata,* great warriors like Droṇa and Aśvatthāmā, etc., were all *brāhmaṇas.* In Vedic times, the *brāhmaṇas* were all agriculturalists. As a social practice, old persons—men and women—and the blind had precedence over kings and *brāhmaṇas.*

Dakṣa says, "One who desires happiness should look on another just as he looks upon himself."[11] Devala says that "the quintessence of *dharma* is that one should not do to others what would be disliked by oneself."[12] The same is repeated in the *Āpastamba-smṛti,* and in other *Smṛtis,* too. Mitākṣara remarks that *ahiṁsā,* or non-hurting, and other qualities are the *dharmas* (duties) common to all, even the *caṇḍālas.*[13] The *Mahābhārata* says that "for protecting a family, one individual may be abandoned; for protecting a town, the family may be abandoned; for protecting the society, the town may be abandoned; and for protecting the true self, even the world may be abandoned."[14] The great empire-builders of India, the Nandas, the Mauryas, and the Guptas, were all low-born. The Gupta emperors married *licchavis* (lower-class dynasty).

Young girls had a decisive voice in the selection of their husbands. On festive occasions and at tournaments girls appeared in all their gaiety. In the Vedic period, women did not suffer from any special disabilities. In the *Mahābhārata,* Śvetaketu's father says, "The women of all classes on earth are free."[15] A single standard for both men and women prevailed. Women were so sacred in India that even the common soldiery left them unmolested in the midst of slaughter and devastation. Wrote Dubois, "A Hindu woman can go anywhere alone, even in the most crowded places, and she need never fear the impertinent looks and jokes of idle loungers.... A house inhabited solely by women is a sanctuary which the most shameless libertine would not dream of violating."[16]

The refrain of the prayer in the *Mahābhārata* is not for the *brāhmaṇas* or for any special class of individuals. We read, "May all beings be happy, may all attain bliss..."[17] This emphasis on *"sarva,"* meaning "all," without distinction of caste, class, or creed, is typical of the Vedic and the Epic literature or periods. The *Āpastamba* declares that "there is nothing higher than the soul" and the *Śatapatha-brāhmaṇa* says, "None among souls is, on the whole, greater than any other soul."[18] Numerous quotations from other sacred literature can be adduced in support of similar social sentiments. When Nārada, a household name in Hindu society, lists